

GNG3100/5100
C4 COIL
The Cost of Inaction

Presented to:

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1. Project Statement

1.1 Understanding the Challenge

When our team first entered the C4 project, we were introduced to a challenge that seemed both familiar and overwhelming: housing insecurity and homelessness. Our initial instinct was to focus on insufficient housing supply, rising rents, and increasing living costs as the main causes of homelessness. However, as we engaged with partner organizations, explored the *Affordability* theme, conducted research, and participated in class discussions, our understanding of the problem became significantly more nuanced.

One of the most important lessons from the C4 process was learning to resist the urge to immediately jump toward solutions. Throughout the course, we were repeatedly encouraged to spend time understanding the problem space, identifying root causes, and examining the larger systems involved before proposing interventions. This approach fundamentally shaped the direction of our project.

Our conversations with partners such as BetterStreet, YSB, and HICC revealed that homelessness is not simply a housing issue. Rather, it is the outcome of interconnected social, economic, and systemic factors. The *Canadian Definition of Homelessness* presented during the course reinforced this understanding by describing homelessness as the result of systemic barriers, financial hardship, discrimination, and a lack of affordable and appropriate housing.

As we continued our research, one observation repeatedly emerged: many people underestimate the true social and economic consequences of housing insecurity. Statistics related to homelessness are often presented in isolation, disconnected from the broader systems and human experiences that surround them. As a result, members of the public, decision-makers, and even stakeholders may not fully appreciate the long-term cost of inaction. This realization became the foundation of our project direction.

Rather than asking, "How do we solve homelessness?", our team reframed the challenge with our theme of *Affordability* in mind, resulting in a different question:

What is the cost of doing nothing?

1.2 Project Title: The Cost of Inaction

Visualizing the Hidden Costs of Housing Insecurity and Homelessness. The title reflects the central message of our project. While discussions surrounding homelessness often focus on immediate visible impacts, much less attention is given to the economic, social, and community costs that result when action is delayed or insufficient. Through research, storytelling, and visual communication, our project seeks to make these hidden costs visible.

1.3 Project Purpose

The purpose of this project is to increase public awareness of the broader impacts of housing insecurity and homelessness through an awareness campaign and infographic. The campaign seeks to encourage the members of the public to reconsider the true cost of homelessness. This includes recognizing the limitations of responses to this crisis and encouraging the public to take action to help their communities by volunteering or addressing the underlying causes. Our project is designed to communicate complex affordability issues in an accessible, engaging, and actionable format. By transforming research findings into compelling visual narratives, we aim to help citizens, community organizations, and decision-makers better understand the consequences of housing insecurity and the importance of preventative action. The project also provides partner organizations with reusable communication materials that can support advocacy efforts, public engagement initiatives, and future funding applications.

1.4 Project Statement

Housing insecurity and homelessness are frequently discussed through isolated statistics rather than interconnected stories and systems. As a result, many citizens, stakeholders, and policymakers may underestimate the long-term social and economic costs associated with housing instability. Without a clear understanding of these impacts, it becomes more difficult to build public support for preventative measures, affordable housing investments, and community-based solutions. Our team identified the following problem statement:

Many people underestimate the broader social and economic impacts of housing insecurity because the consequences are often presented as isolated statistics rather than interconnected human stories. As a result, policymakers, stakeholders, and members of the public may not fully understand the long-term costs of inaction or the benefits of investing in affordable housing and homelessness prevention.

1.5 Project Goal

The primary goal of our project is to communicate the hidden costs of housing insecurity and homelessness through an impactful awareness campaign supported by evidence-based research and visual storytelling.

More specifically, our project aims to:

- Increase public awareness of affordability challenges
- Highlight the broader societal costs associated with homelessness
- Transform complex research findings into accessible visual communication
- Encourage discussion about preventative action rather than reactive responses
- Provide partner organizations with reusable advocacy and educational materials
- Support evidence-based conversations regarding affordability and housing insecurity

1.6 Project Need

Throughout our research, we found that affordability is not simply an economic issue; it is a systems issue. Housing instability affects employment, education, transportation, healthcare, food security, and community well-being. However, these relationships are often invisible to the public because data is typically presented in fragmented ways. Our team identified a need for communication tools that connect these different elements into a coherent narrative. Rather than producing another report filled with statistics, we sought to create a resource that could help audiences understand the broader picture and recognize why early intervention matters. The need for this project is therefore not only informational but educational. By helping people see the connections between affordability, homelessness, and broader social outcomes, we hope to encourage more informed public dialogue and decision-making.

1.7 Stakeholders

Because our project focuses on awareness, advocacy, and evidence-based communication rather than direct service delivery, our stakeholders differ from those of a traditional housing intervention. The project is intended to influence both decision-makers and the broader public by helping them better understand the social and economic consequences of housing insecurity and homelessness. Throughout the project charter development process, our team identified four key stakeholder groups that would either directly use our deliverables or be influenced by the information presented through the campaign.

Stakeholder Group	Category	Interest in Project	Expected Impact
People Experiencing Homelessness or Housing Insecurity	Primary	Indirect beneficiaries of improved awareness, advocacy, and policy discussions	Increased visibility of lived experiences and systemic challenges affecting housing stability
Taxpayers / General Public	Primary	Often have limited understanding of the systemic costs associated with homelessness	Greater awareness of how housing insecurity affects communities and public spending, encouraging informed civic engagement
Non-Profit Housing and Community Organizations (BetterStreet, YSB, HICC, and similar organizations)	Primary	Need communication and advocacy tools to support public engagement and funding efforts	Reusable infographic, awareness materials, and data storytelling resources for advocacy and education
Policymakers (municipal, provincial, and federal)	Primary	Require evidence to support housing and affordability decisions	Increased awareness of the long-term economic and social costs of inaction, supporting more informed policy discussions
Researchers and Academic Communities	Secondary	Interested in communicating complex social issues to broader audiences	Example of knowledge mobilization and data storytelling for public education
Future Advocacy Campaigns and Community Initiatives	Secondary	May adapt or build upon campaign materials	Long-term use and adaptation of project outputs beyond the C4 project

1.8 Scope and Boundaries

One of the most important lessons from our project was recognizing the importance of defining realistic boundaries. Early discussions generated ambitious ideas ranging from integrated affordability platforms to employment placement programs. However, through stakeholder feedback, systems analysis, and constraint evaluation, our team recognized that homelessness is far too complex to be addressed through a single intervention

developed within a two-week project. As a result, we intentionally narrowed our focus to creating a practical and reusable awareness campaign centred on the concept of **The Cost of Inaction**. The campaign seeks to help audiences understand the consequences of maintaining the status quo while providing partner organizations with communication tools that can continue to be used after the completion of the C4 project.

Project Scope

The project includes:

- Development of a public awareness campaign focused on the social and economic costs of housing insecurity and homelessness.
- Creation of a data-driven infographic supported by evidence-based research.
- Use of data storytelling and visual communication techniques to make complex information more accessible.
- Focus on affordability and homelessness data within Ontario, based on partner feedback and project constraints.
- Encouraging public engagement, reflection, and discussion through posters, visual materials, and supporting communication assets.

Project Boundaries

The project does not include:

- Solving homelessness directly
- Developing or implementing public policy
- Constructing affordable housing
- Creating separate reports for multiple organizations
- Operating social programs or support services
- Developing a fully functional affordability platform
- Maintaining long-term datasets or updating information after project completion
- Providing direct assistance to individuals experiencing homelessness

These boundaries were established to ensure that the project remained achievable, evidence-based, and useful to our partners. By narrowing our scope, we were able to focus our efforts on producing a high-quality awareness campaign and infographic rather than attempting to create a solution that would exceed our available time, resources, and capacity. Most importantly, these boundaries allowed us to create a deliverable that aligns with the needs identified by our partners while remaining sustainable and realistic within the context of the C4 project.

1.9 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Our project aligns with several United Nations Sustainable Development Goals, particularly those related to poverty reduction, social equity, sustainable communities, and collaborative action. By raising awareness of the social and economic impacts of housing insecurity and homelessness, the project supports broader efforts to promote informed decision-making, community engagement, and evidence-based advocacy. The SDGs most closely connected to our project are **SDG 1 (No Poverty)**, **SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities)**, **SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities)**, and **SDG 17 (Partnerships for the Goals)**. A more detailed assessment of these connections is provided in Section 7 of this report.

1.10 Project Overview: The 5W Framework

Category	Description
Who?	People Experiencing Homelessness or Housing Insecurity, Taxpayers / General Public, Non-Profit Housing and Community Organizations, Policymakers, Researchers and Academic Communities, Future Advocacy Campaigns and Community Initiatives
What?	A data storytelling awareness campaign and infographic that communicates the hidden social and economic costs of housing insecurity and homelessness through visual storytelling.
When?	Developed during the Summer 2026 Cross-Campus Capstone Classroom (C4) and designed to remain usable by partner organizations beyond the completion of the course.
Where?	Focused primarily on Ontario, while reflecting broader Canadian affordability and homelessness trends.
How?	Through research, systems thinking, stakeholder engagement, public data analysis, visual communication, infographic development, and awareness campaign design.
Why?	To help audiences better understand the consequences of inaction, increase awareness of housing insecurity, and provide partners with communication tools that support advocacy, education, and public engagement efforts.

2. Project Justification

Based on our research, we found that the issue of affordability is a large-scale problem that can only be resolved through a national strategy implemented by provincial and federal governments. Governments need to invest in public housing in order to tackle the high cost of housing across Canada. One study showed that public housing funding in the Toronto region needs to more than double the current budget over the next 25 years in order to reduce homelessness (Canadian Centre for Economic Analysis [CANCEA], 2026).

Other approaches to providing affordable housing include implementing rent caps, legislating new tenant protections, and taxing corporate landlords. However, the current federal government and the Ontario provincial government have shown more support for corporations and big business than for protecting the public interest. There are reports indicating that landlord lobbyists advocating for easier evictions and the removal of rent control have influenced Premier Doug Ford's housing policies (Thompson, 2022).

These corporate-friendly policies are contributing to a growing increase in homelessness (Association of Municipalities of Ontario [AMO], 2025) which imposes significant human and financial costs on the province. Spending on homelessness programs in Ontario increased from \$2.04 billion in 2024 to \$2.3 billion in 2025, an increase of \$229.9 million (11.3%) (Association of Municipalities of Ontario [AMO], 2026). The crisis also creates costs for other public services, such as the healthcare and justice systems. The cost of homelessness in London is estimated at more than \$100,000 per person per year, broken down approximately as follows:

- Healthcare: approximately \$12,200
- Emergency response services (e.g., police, fire, EMS): $\approx$ \$15,700
- Social services and shelter use: $\approx$ \$12,800
- Additional collective costs
(e.g., incarceration, judicial system, charitable supports): $>$ \$73,000 (City of London, 2025)

All in all, our project findings made it clear that a small-scale initiative, especially one that is feasible and viable within a three-week timeline, is incapable of meaningfully addressing affordability. The team determined that the most realistic course of action is an advocacy campaign targeted at the general public. The campaign seeks to shift the framing of the issue. The question should not be the cost of addressing homelessness, but rather the cost of inaction and maintaining the status quo. We hope to engage the public with the issue of homelessness by demonstrating how their tax dollars are being spent on crisis responses and long-term support services, rather than on reducing the flow of people before they reach that level of need.

Our validation process involved comparing multiple solution directions against the evidence gathered from government reports, nonprofit organizations, partner presentations, and public datasets. Initially, we explored the idea of developing a platform that would centralize affordability-related resources and services. However, feedback from partners and our review of the research revealed that the larger challenge was not only the availability of services, but also public awareness and understanding of the issue itself.

Several sources highlighted that homelessness disproportionately affects vulnerable populations. Indigenous peoples represent approximately 5% of Canada's population but account for roughly 35% of people experiencing homelessness. Youth represent approximately 20% of the homeless population, while 24% identify as 2SLGBTQ+. These findings reinforced the importance of approaching the problem through an equity and systems lens rather than focusing solely on housing supply. (Canadian Observatory on Homelessness. (2023). *Who experiences homelessness?* Homeless Hub)

The research also showed that many people underestimate the true economic impact of homelessness. Studies indicate that significant public resources are spent on emergency shelters, healthcare interventions, crisis services, and justice-system responses after people become homeless. At the same time, reports emphasized that increased investment in prevention and affordable housing could reduce these long-term societal costs. This insight became the foundation of our project concept. (Housing, Infrastructure and Communities Canada. (2024). *Chronic homelessness in Canada, 2017–2023*. Government of Canada.)

As a result of this validation process, our team shifted from a broad affordability platform toward a focused communication and awareness tool. We concluded that our most meaningful contribution within the scope of a two-week project was to help audiences better understand the hidden social and economic costs of housing insecurity. Our final infographic and storytelling approach were therefore designed to transform complex data into accessible, engaging, and human-centred information that could support more informed public discussion and decision-making.

3. Project Design Thinking - Réflexion sur la conception du projet

Pensée SOUnD - Sound Thinking

La pensée SOUnD a agi moins comme une liste de vérification que comme une lentille, un point de vue que l'équipe utilisait : nous revenions sans cesse à trois questions principales, offrons-nous quelque chose qui aura un effet après le C4, faisons-nous quelque chose d'unique, et nos parties prenantes visées pourront-elles réellement l'utiliser? Comme notre équipe provenait de plusieurs programmes différents, affaires, génie, français, science politique et autres, nous avons tous des perspectives différentes. Cette réflexion sur le problème nous a amenés à

rechercher une solution durable, sans dépasser le budget ni créer davantage de travail pour nos partenaires : notre solution est une campagne de sensibilisation à faible coût et facile à utiliser, accompagnée d'une infographie que nos partenaires peuvent réutiliser. Nous tenions à sortir des sentiers battus en reformulant notre question : plutôt que de nous demander comment lutter contre l'itinérance, nous avons demandé ce que coûte l'inaction, le coût de l'inaction, afin de raconter cette histoire grâce à l'effet de choc de la campagne de sensibilisation. L'aspect universel tient au fait que nous cherchons à créer une campagne de sensibilisation rapide et frappante, appuyée par une infographie plus détaillée et utilisable que nos parties prenantes peuvent consulter.

Constrained a nos Solutions - Constraints of our solutions

Une fois que l'équipe a compris quel était le problème principal et comment aborder la création d'une solution, les contraintes nous sont apparues rapidement, car nous les avons rattachées à nos partenaires. Les contraintes strictes que nous avons identifiées en équipe étaient d'abord la portée de la solution : nous n'allions pas régler l'itinérance en deux semaines. Alors, comment créer quelque chose que nos partenaires pourraient utiliser? Le budget et le personnel constituaient une autre contrainte majeure, suivie de l'accès aux données, ainsi que de la nécessité d'assumer une certaine responsabilité et d'imputabilité afin de démontrer que les données présentées sont appropriées et réelles. À partir de ces contraintes, nous les avons utilisées pour bâtir les critères qui nous ont servi à choisir notre solution principale et à nous assurer qu'elle respectait ce que nous avons inscrit dans la charte d'équipe.

Processus D'Ideation - Ideation Process

Les visites de terrain et les rencontres avec les partenaires ont réellement aidé l'équipe à établir un processus d'idéation clair et à concevoir plusieurs alternatives. Ces alternatives ont toutes été examinées et discutées au sein de l'équipe et avec les partenaires. Voici la liste des alternatives potentielles que l'équipe a discutées :

Alternative 1: Programme de mini-stages. Un programme structuré de placements professionnels à court terme, principalement axé sur les jeunes, en partenariat avec des organismes locaux afin d'offrir une expérience rémunérée à faible barrière d'entrée et des compétences d'employabilité (entrevues, travail d'équipe, comportement professionnel). Il ciblait directement la génération de revenus. Les partenaires l'ont apprécié (YSB adorait l'idée du stage), mais ont souligné qu'il faudrait un organisme de première ligne pour le mettre réellement en œuvre. Cela entraînait en conflit avec nos contraintes de temps et de budget.

Alternative 2: Plateforme d'abordabilité intégrée. Une passerelle centralisée et conviviale vers les services existants, qui comprendrait le logement, l'alimentation, le transport, l'emploi et la santé, avec la possibilité de chercher selon les besoins, l'emplacement et l'admissibilité, des cartes de services, l'appariement d'admissibilité et un accès multilingue. Cela répondait à notre

cause profonde, mais l'intégration des données est un processus long et difficile; une grande partie des données est restreinte, et la plateforme nécessiterait quelqu'un pour l'entretenir après le cours. C'était donc une excellente idée, mais au mauvais moment.

Alternative 3: Narration par la visualisation de données. Une campagne de sensibilisation et une infographie fondées sur la reformulation du “coût de l'inaction”, diffusées au moyen d'affiches, de publicités et de médias sociaux, accompagnées d'un rapport réutilisable que les partenaires pourraient utiliser pour obtenir du financement. Cette alternative offrait un livrable que les partenaires peuvent utiliser, ainsi qu'un public ciblé pour la campagne de sensibilisation. La recherche fournie par notre équipe nous semblait trop importante pour ne pas être présentée. La principale contrainte mentionnée par HICC était que l'infographie devrait être mise à jour lors de la parution du nouveau recensement de 2026.

Il y a eu une certaine discussion sur la fusion des alternatives 2 et 3, ce qui donnerait une narration par les données menant à la plateforme. Plusieurs idées ont aussi été abordées, notamment celle d'une plateforme de recherche ou de la création d'un site d'offres d'emploi. Tout cela a été examiné à travers les énoncés de problèmes de l'équipe et la manière dont nous pouvions assurer une solution viable pour nos partenaires et notre public.

Processus de Convergence - Convergence Process

La convergence s'est produite lorsque nous avons repassé les trois alternatives à travers nos contraintes et nos critères, et la rétroaction des partenaires lors de la présentation de lancement a rendu la décision très facile à cerner. À cette aune, l'alternative 1 échouait sur le plan du personnel et de la faisabilité opérationnelle, et l'alternative 2 échouait sur l'accès aux données et les contraintes de temps. L'alternative 3 franchissait toutes les contraintes : faible coût, aucun personnel permanent, réalisable à partir de données publiques dans notre échéancier, et utile aux partenaires. De plus, nous avons suivi le conseil des partenaires de réduire l'échelle, en resserrant notre champ sur les statistiques et les données de l'Ontario et de la région du Grand Toronto (GTA) afin de demeurer dans la portée visée.

Tests et Validations - Validations and Tests

Nos livrables pour les partenaires étant centrés sur la communication et les données, les tests et la validation de l'équipe se sont faits avec les parties qui utiliseraient réellement ces livrables. Les partenaires se sont joints à nous en ligne et nous avons pu recueillir leurs recommandations et leurs observations pour faire progresser la campagne de sensibilisation et l'infographie. Ces partenaires comprenaient Better Street, YSB et HICC. L'équipe a également mis à profit la rétroaction reçue lors du lancement du projet ainsi que les résultats et commentaires de la journée de démonstration (Demo Day) pour orienter la sélection et la création de notre solution finale. Ces validations et commentaires des partenaires au cours des deux semaines nous ont fourni des perspectives précieuses

4. Outputs & Outcomes

4.1 From Research to Action

Throughout the project, our team repeatedly encountered the same challenge: affordability and homelessness are often discussed through statistics, budgets, and policy debates, yet many members of the public remain disconnected from the broader consequences of these issues. As we explored homelessness through research, stakeholder engagement, and systems thinking, we realized that a small-scale student project would not be capable of directly solving affordability challenges. Housing insecurity is a complex systems problem influenced by housing markets, income inequality, public policy, social services, healthcare systems, and community supports. Addressing these interconnected issues requires long-term action from governments, organizations, and communities. Recognizing these limitations led our team to ask a different question. This shift became the foundation of our project. Our research suggested that public conversations often focus on the cost of homelessness interventions while overlooking the significant social and economic costs associated with maintaining the status quo. Emergency shelters, healthcare services, crisis response systems, social programs, and public services all absorb costs when housing insecurity is left unaddressed. As a result, our team chose to develop **The Cost of Inaction**, a public awareness campaign designed to reframe the conversation surrounding homelessness and affordability. Rather than advocating for a specific policy solution, the campaign encourages audiences to reflect on the hidden costs of inaction and the long-term consequences of failing to address housing insecurity before individuals reach crisis situations.

4.2 Overview of the Final Deliverables

The final project consists of several interconnected deliverables that work together to communicate the project's core message and support public awareness regarding housing insecurity and homelessness.

Awareness Campaign

The primary deliverable of the project is a public awareness campaign centered on the concept of **The Cost of Inaction**. The campaign was designed to challenge common assumptions surrounding homelessness by encouraging audiences to think differently about the issue. Rather than asking whether society can afford to invest in prevention and support services, the campaign asks whether society can afford not to. Using data storytelling, visual communication, and evidence-based messaging, the campaign highlights the financial and social consequences associated with maintaining the status quo. It draws attention to the reality that public resources are often spent responding to crises after they occur rather than preventing individuals from reaching those situations in the first place.

The campaign targets several audiences, including:

- Taxpayers and members of the general public;
- Policymakers and government decision-makers;
- Non-profit and housing organizations;
- Community advocates and stakeholders.

By encouraging reflection and discussion, the campaign seeks to increase awareness of the broader impacts of housing insecurity while supporting conversations about prevention, affordability, and long-term community well-being.

Data-Driven Infographic

The infographic serves as the central component of the awareness campaign and acts as the primary vehicle for communicating the project's message. Drawing on public datasets, government reports, homelessness statistics, and research conducted throughout the project, the infographic was designed to answer a simple but powerful question:

What does homelessness cost when we choose not to act?

Rather than presenting homelessness solely as a social issue, the infographic encourages audiences to view it through the lens of public spending, community impacts, and long-term societal consequences. By connecting affordability challenges to emergency responses, support services, and taxpayer-funded systems, the infographic helps illustrate how the cost of maintaining the status quo extends far beyond those directly experiencing homelessness.

The infographic was designed to:

- Reframe public conversations around homelessness and affordability;
- Highlight the economic and social costs associated with inaction;
- Demonstrate how public resources are often spent on crisis response rather than prevention;
- Encourage reflection among taxpayers, policymakers, and community stakeholders;
- Support advocacy and awareness-building efforts undertaken by partner organizations.

A key design objective was to balance evidence with accessibility. Rather than overwhelming audiences with large quantities of information, the infographic focuses on a small number of compelling statistics and messages that support the central narrative of the campaign.

Campaign Assets and Visual Materials

To support the awareness campaign, the team developed a series of complementary visual assets designed to capture attention and encourage public engagement. These materials include campaign posters, awareness messages, promotional visuals, and presentation materials developed for stakeholder engagement and Demo Day. Each asset was designed to serve as an entry point into the broader conversation surrounding affordability and homelessness. The campaign intentionally uses concise messaging and visual storytelling techniques to encourage audiences to stop, reflect, and question common assumptions surrounding homelessness. Through posters and visual prompts, audiences are invited to consider whether current approaches are addressing the problem effectively or simply managing its consequences. Together, these materials strengthen the campaign's ability to communicate complex issues in a way that is accessible, memorable, and impactful.

4.3 How the Project Addresses the Identified Problem

Through data storytelling, visual communication, and carefully selected evidence, the project translates complex information into a format that encourages reflection and discussion. By making the hidden costs more visible, the campaign seeks to strengthen public awareness and support more informed conversations about prevention, affordability, and long-term community well-being.

Identified Problem	Project Response
Limited public understanding of homelessness and affordability	Awareness campaign focused on education and engagement
Public discussions often overlook the cost of maintaining the status quo	Reframing the issue through the concept of the Cost of Inaction
Research and statistics are often inaccessible to the public	Data storytelling and visual communication
Need for advocacy and awareness tools	Reusable campaign materials and infographic assets

4.4 Implementation Strategy

The project was intentionally designed as a low-cost and highly adaptable awareness initiative. Rather than requiring new infrastructure, technology, or operational resources, the

campaign can be implemented through existing communication channels used by partner organizations and community stakeholders.

Potential implementation methods include:

- Partner websites;
- Social media campaigns;
- Community outreach initiatives;
- Public awareness events;
- Educational presentations;
- Advocacy and stakeholder engagement activities.

Because the campaign relies primarily on publicly available data and reusable visual materials, implementation barriers remain relatively low. Partner organizations can adapt, redistribute, or expand upon the campaign according to their specific needs and audiences. As new affordability and homelessness data become available, future versions of the infographic may also be updated to maintain relevance and accuracy.

4.5 Expected Impact

Although the project does not directly provide housing, employment opportunities, or social services, it seeks to influence the conversations and perceptions that shape public understanding of homelessness and affordability.

Stakeholders	Impact
Taxpayers and The General Public	The campaign specifically encourages taxpayers and members of the public to consider how public funds are currently being spent on crisis responses, emergency services, and long-term support systems. By making these costs more visible, the project seeks to encourage more informed discussions regarding prevention and affordability.
Community Organizations	Organizations such as BetterStreet, YSB, and HICC may use the campaign as an advocacy and awareness-building tool to support public engagement efforts and strengthen conversations surrounding housing insecurity.
Policymakers	By illustrating the broader economic and social consequences of inaction, the campaign may help

	decision-makers better understand the value of preventative approaches and long-term investments in housing stability.
Future Advocacy Efforts	The campaign framework and infographic can continue to be used, adapted, and expanded by organizations seeking to raise awareness about housing insecurity and affordability challenges in the future.

4.6 Project Value Beyond C4

One of the primary goals of our team was to create a deliverable that would remain useful beyond the duration of the course. Because the campaign is based on awareness, education, and advocacy rather than direct service delivery, it has the potential to continue generating value after the completion of C4. Partner organizations may reuse the campaign materials, adapt the messaging for future initiatives, or update the infographic as new information becomes available. Ultimately, the value of the project lies not in its ability to solve homelessness directly, but in its ability to encourage a different conversation. By shifting attention toward the costs of inaction, the campaign invites audiences to reconsider how homelessness is understood, discussed, and addressed within our communities.

5. Ethics Statement

From the start, a big concern we had was the approach. Many awareness campaigns have unintentionally depicted homeless people as an “other”, a problem to be solved, a statistic people should be appalled by. The tragedy of this approach is it can often decrease public empathy rather than build it. To not fall into this trap, our approach focused more on systems, government spending, and government responsibility rather than on homeless people. The main idea of the posters and infographic is to hold a mirror to taxpayers in a way they can see themselves in the issue. Not to feel sorry for someone else but to stop and consider where their money goes. We saw this shift of focus as the best way to keep the dignity of the people our campaign is ultimately about intact.

As a team, decisions were made mostly collaboratively, and we had real conversations on the direction of the honesty of our project. Everyone’s input was treated with value and respect, and credit was shared openly and embraced. When earlier ideas relied too much on shock value, we reworked and improved with feedback. It felt like a collective group effort rather than separate tasks being arbitrarily assigned.

Throughout the entire project, we had a DEI lens for specific decisions that came up often. Not only was the language across all materials kept accessible with both French and English dialogue, but we also kept the language used clear and concise. The diversity assessment

acknowledged that homelessness does not affect all groups equally; youth in the foster system, disabled people abandoned by the government, and other communities are overrepresented in homeless populations. While the campaign's current scope focuses on the affordability argument, the team recognized this as a limitation. A more complete version of the campaign would give space to those specific experiences and make the equity dimension as visible as the economic one.

6. Connection to UN Sustainable Development Goals

Although The Cost of Inaction is a relatively small-scale awareness campaign, it aligns with several United Nations Sustainable Development Goals by promoting public awareness, encouraging informed decision-making, and supporting conversations surrounding housing insecurity and affordability. While our project does not directly deliver housing, financial assistance, or social services, it contributes to the broader ecosystem of knowledge, advocacy, and community engagement that supports long-term social change. For its SDG assessment, the project was reviewed through all 17 UN Sustainable Development Goals with five being singled out as the most relevant in terms of our purposes.

First, there is the SDG 1 (No Poverty): The logic is that housing investments are the main way out of poverty, being a more viable alternative to continuous mitigation. The second critical goal is SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-Being) and it was chosen because having housing means better psychological and physical health. One of the main connections and expenses highlighted by the campaign is linked to ambulances, emergency room costs, and crisis intervention. SDG 4 (Quality Education) is relevant because of the understanding that children and youth moving from the foster care system to homelessness are significantly disadvantaged and therefore have their education interrupted. Next, SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities) represents the core of the campaign's message because homelessness is considered one of the most severe forms of social exclusion, one that the current system maintains rather than solves. Finally, SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities) unites all goals by placing homelessness in the framework of a problem shared by all Canadians from small tight knit communities to large cities.

Overall, the campaign is fairly effective in achieving its impact regarding the SDGs showcased. This is mainly because posters, QR codes, and infographics all fit well within the scope of these particular SDGs because they frame homelessness as a systemic problem that requires a financial investment in addition to a shift in attitudes from the general public toward this population. And in addition, the Instagram account will be helpful for reaching out to youth audiences that are more engaged with this topic.

To increase the SDG impact, a separate dedicated poster or infographic related to youth aging out of foster care and into homelessness would help SDG 4. Also, the campaign should

include an explicit statistic on how much Ontario spends on ER visits caused by homelessness because this information will increase the impact of SDG 3 in this regard. As a solution for SDG 10, posters might include wording that emphasizes inequalities involved so the average person can empathize with it from someone else's shoes. Finally, for SDG 11, the next step is cooperation with student organizations or partners who can share the Instagram page posts and give them more reach.

Reflection on SDG Impact

Our project contributes most strongly to the SDGs through awareness-building, education, and advocacy rather than direct intervention. While the campaign does not directly reduce homelessness or provide housing services, it supports the broader ecosystem of organizations and stakeholders working toward these goals by promoting informed public discussion and encouraging reflection on the costs of maintaining the status quo. As an awareness campaign, its impact depends largely on how the materials are used by partner organizations and how audiences engage with the information presented. Future iterations of the project could increase their SDG impact through expanded stakeholder participation, broader community outreach, and regular updates using new affordability and homelessness data.

7. Process of Completion - Processus d'achèvement

Processus de Realization - Process of Completion

Notre flux de travail reposait sur une forte collaboration d'équipe: la recherche et les visites des partenaires, puis les discussions d'équipe qui transformaient ce matériel brut en options; la rétroaction des partenaires qui réduisait le nombre d'options; et la possibilité d'en discuter en groupe. Nous nous coordonnons au moyen de mises à jour quotidiennes sur WhatsApp, en confiant chaque livrable à la personne la mieux placée pour le prendre en charge. Les ébauches passaient par une révision collaborative (première, deuxième, version finale) avant la remise, ce qui explique la façon dont le rapport de mi-parcours a été assemblé, tout comme le présent rapport, et la manière dont la présentation du Demo Day a pris forme. Le processus de réalisation s'est déroulé comme itératif qui a utilisé les principes de C4. L'équipe passait d'une phase d'idéation à l'identification du problème, puis à la conception de la manière dont nous allions l'aborder. De plus, c'est ainsi que nous avons appréhendé les "Sprints", en passant du format "cupcake" au "whole cake", comme discuté lors de la session centrale de C4. Les sprints nous ont permis de rester concentrés sur les tâches principales immédiates à accomplir dans un court délai, tout en comprenant la vision d'ensemble du gâteau, ce qui était l'objectif visé.

Individual Contributions to the Project and Report

- Andrew

- For the project itself, Andrew worked on the research that was used for the Infographic. He also contributed to the main design of the infographic and ensured to highlight the main information that the Team wanted to illustrate from the research. In the final report, Andrew was able to contribute to the Project Design Thinking, the process of completion, and helped with the Interdisciplinary Reflection.
- **May**
 - The initial idea behind the project was to advertise in public spaces, to pivot to digital spaces since physical spaces turned out to be outside of the team's budget; prepared a list of potential 'call to action' as part of the ad campaign, generating ideas for the ad campaign 'hook'. Co-led research on affordability, homelessness, and housing insecurity by analyzing government reports, partner resources, and public datasets. In the final report, May contributed to the Project Justification section.
- **Sara**
 - For the project itself, Sara co-led research on affordability, homelessness, and housing insecurity. She identified and analyzed government reports, partner resources, and public datasets that informed the team's problem definition and project direction. She contributed to problem definition, stakeholder research, and systems-thinking activities. She also supported the development of the infographic, awareness campaign, project messaging, and first presentation materials. In the final report, Sara contributed to the Project Justification, the Project Itself and the Connection to SDG Goals.
- **Chris**
 - For the project, Chris worked mostly on the awareness campaign side of it. He also spent extensive time researching previous campaigns of this nature from not only university students but also non-local sources to see what worked and what didn't. After collecting data, he then went off designing the original versions of the posters, from accessible colour grading to engaging images and text. When the team pivoted to more online engagement, he also tailored posts to engage as many people as possible. For the final report, Chris was responsible for the Ethics Statement, part of the Connection to the SDG Goals, and various parts of the Appendix.
- **Emily**
 - As for the project itself, Emily worked on the awareness campaign side of it. She first started on the potential designs for the posters. She then contacted different advertising companies such as Pattison for the TTC interior horizontal cards, as well as the advertising departments for York University, Yorkdale Mall, Fairview Mall, and Spotify, to inquire about pricing and availability. After figuring out that

they were all out of our budget range, she made a decision with her team, and they settled on Instagram and Facebook ads. She was then tasked with creating a Gmail account, an Instagram account, and a Facebook account to be able to figure out how to post an Ad and check the policies, considering we are planning on the “ad” being about a “social issue”. For the final report, Emily was in charge of the project statement questions, as well as the references.

Table of Contributions

Team Member	Subject Matter Expertise	Role(s)
Andrew Earley	Business	Project Management, Idea Generation, Problem Definition, Research.
Chris Ogbeiwi	Engineering	Devil’s Advocate, Resource Investigator, Visual Designer
May Sharifi	Political Science	Project Coordinator, Researcher Co-lead, Concept Developer
Emily Broersma	French Studies Francophone Stream	Facilitator, Visual Designer, Scheduling Coordinator, Translator, Site Documenter.
Sara Samihi	Multidisciplinary Design Engineering	Researcher Co-lead, Implementer

Résumez des Sprints et Résultats - Summarized Sprints and Results

Lors de la planification, chacun de nous s'engageait sur les heures qu'il pouvait offrir et tirait des tâches sur le tableau Miro, qui circulaient du “Backlog : Plus tard/Bientôt” vers Suivant, Maintenant, En cours et Terminé, avec un code de couleur par personne et un autre pour l'équipe entière. La fenêtre de 24 heures: nous nous engageons sur un petit lot de travail (créer notre nom d'équipe, faire la recherche, créer des concepts de visualisation), nous l'accomplissons, puis nous le révélions, plutôt que de planifier tout le projet. À la revue, nous avons constaté que nous réalisons la plupart des notes autocollantes attribuées individuellement, mais que certaines tâches d'équipe passaient entre les mailles du filet. Ensuite, la rétrospective nous a montré comment chacun se sentait après, ce qui a vraiment aidé l'équipe. Cela donnait à chacun une idée de son état d'esprit et de ses points d'amélioration. Parmi les notes, on trouvait ce qui avait bien fonctionné, comme la recherche de données et la planification de la solution finale, et des exemples de choses à faire différemment, comme être davantage sur la même longueur d'onde et rester concentrés sur la tâche à accomplir.

Réflexion sur la Gestion du Projet - Project Management Reflection

Nous croyons qu'en équipe, certaines choses ont fonctionné et d'autres moins. Ce qui nous a aidés à mieux travailler ensemble, c'est le clavardage quotidien sur WhatsApp, le modèle flexible qui permettait à chacun de jouer sur ses forces, et le fait de prendre les grandes décisions en groupe pour que personne ne se sente dépassé. Le caractère bilingue de l'équipe a été davantage un atout qu'un obstacle. Il y a aussi des aspects que l'équipe aurait pu améliorer. Nous estimons avoir commencé de façon trop large et avoir perdu un temps précieux pour la conception de la solution; il aurait été préférable d'attribuer les rôles plus tôt afin d'éviter de devoir courir à l'approche des échéances. Nos présentations se sont améliorées avec le temps, mais nous aurions pu utiliser un meilleur scénario et une meilleure préparation pour la présentation de lancement et le Demo Day. L'équipe aurait également pu mieux communiquer : comme nous l'avons indiqué dans la charte d'équipe, la communication figurait parmi nos faiblesses, et si nous l'avions reconnue plus tôt, nous aurions pu faire mieux.

8. Réflexion Interdisciplinaire - Interdisciplinary Reflection -

Réflexion de différentes approches disciplinaires - Reflection on different disciplinary approaches

Nous avons une belle diversité de programmes, et chacun de nous a pu façonner la solution d'une manière différente. May a su utiliser ses compétences pour concevoir le problème et reformuler la question sous l'angle de l'inaction. Sara a pu apporter sa pensée systémique et mettre à profit ses compétences techniques pour aider à créer les livrables. Andrew a fourni une conception de l'infographie que les partenaires pourraient utiliser. Emily a employé ses compétences pour faire des recherches sur les publicités et créer la campagne de sensibilisation avec Chris. Chris a su utiliser ses capacités de recherche pour élaborer les concepts de la campagne de sensibilisation et la façon de capter l'effet de choc. De plus, les partenaires ont aidé notre équipe quant aux différentes approches que nous adoptons et aux principaux aspects à considérer (organismes de première ligne, accessibilité des données, pensée d'entreprise sociale et compréhension de la perspective d'évaluation des politiques). La synthèse a été atteinte autour du concept final du "coût de l'inaction": un livrable ancré dans les politiques publiques, géré comme un projet, conçu pour répondre aux besoins des partenaires et apte à sensibiliser le grand public.

Les Défis - The Challenges

La synthèse a pris du temps pour notre équipe; le principal défi tenait au fait que nous avions tous des perspectives différentes, en raison de nos parcours et de nos programmes variés

comme science politique, génie, affaires, sciences sociales. De plus, nous nous retrouvions à vouloir voir comment améliorer continuellement la solution tout en restant fidèles à la même orientation. Nous avons aussi eu de la difficulté à décider s'il fallait pencher vers le volet affaires (les stages), le volet plateforme de données ou le volet élaboration de politiques. Comme nous sommes tous dans des programmes différents, nous avons l'impression de ne pas pouvoir mener ces solutions à terme, puisqu'une seule personne de l'équipe possédait des connaissances préalables dans chaque domaine. Par ailleurs, certains conflits d'horaire ont rendu difficile la possibilité de nous réunir et de travailler ensemble, car nous venons de trois universités différentes, avons des horaires distincts et des disponibilités en ligne limitées. Cela dit, la synthèse a exigé de réels efforts et beaucoup de travail d'équipe.

Synthèse Disciplinaire - Disciplinary Synthesis

De nombreux aspects ont grandement facilité la synthèse. Les énoncés de problèmes communs et la méthode des 5 Pourquoi ont donné à tous une base initiale pour discuter et faire la recherche. De plus, la rétroaction des partenaires et les visites de terrain ont beaucoup aidé l'équipe : elles ont agi comme une partie neutre, de sorte que, lorsque nous discussions d'idées, nous revenions toujours à ce que le partenaire souhaitait voir, ce qui nous servait de critère. Le tableau de sprint a aussi facilité les choses : lorsque nous discussions des tâches et des livrables en équipe, il nous ouvrait la porte pour décider de la façon d'aborder les tâches et de l'objectif visé pour chaque partie. Mais la principale facilitation a été les points quotidiens : ce temps d'équipe nous permettait de discuter face à face (ou, dans notre cas, d'écran à écran) de tout désaccord ou de toute approche pour développer les solutions ou les tâches.

9. Professional Project Video

The link for the video can be found on this channel: [Professional Project Video - C1](#)

10. Appendix

10.1 - Ontario's Homelessness Crisis Infographic

ONTARIO'S HOMELESSNESS CRISIS

THE FULLPICTURE: WHO, WHERE, WHAT IT COSTS— AND WHAT IT WOULD TAKE TO END IT

AMO / OMSSA / NOSDA, 2025&2026

C4 Capstone
Team C1 — Affordability
The Cost of Doing Nothing

1 HOMELESSNESS INCREASED AGAIN IN 2025

84,973

Ontarians experienced known homelessness in 2025

+7.8%

6,173 more people than the year before — growth has not been reversed since the pandemic.

GROWTH IS ACCELERATING

+6.3% 2016–2021

+49.1% 2021–2025

Known homelessness growth rate, Ontario

2 GROWING FASTEST WHERE SERVICES ARE THINNEST

+37.3%

Growth in known homelessness in NORTHERN ONTARIO in one year (2024–25), the fastest in the province.

+31.0%

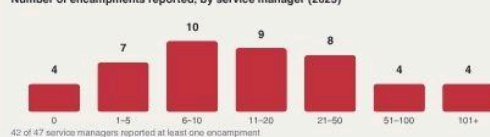
Growth in mostly RURAL communities (2024–25) is almost four times the provincial rate of +7.8%.

2.9% vs 13.2%

13.2% of people experiencing homelessness are Indigenous people, who represent 2.9% of Ontario's population

3 ENCAMPMENTS NOW EXIST IN MOST OF ONTARIO

Number of encampments reported, by service manager (2025)



~2,000

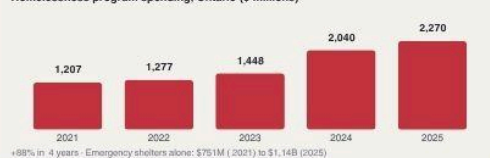
Site-based encampments across Ontario in 2025 — most small and dispersed (50% involve 2–10 people).

~8,100

Vulnerable people unsheltered at a point in time, in tents, vehicles, or places not meant for habitation.

4 SPENDING KEEPS RISING — AND CHASES THE EMERGENCY

Homelessness program spending, Ontario (\$ millions)



+11.3%

Spending growth in one year (+\$229.9M, 2024–25): Shelters +\$107.5M, Supportive housing +\$37.9M, Outreach +\$4.5%.

–10.4%

Prevention & diversion was CUT from \$96.5M to \$88.3M — the only major program area to shrink.

\$4.0B+

Combined Housing & Homelessness funding in 2025 — Almost doubled 2018's \$2.1B, a +103% increase

\$2.0B

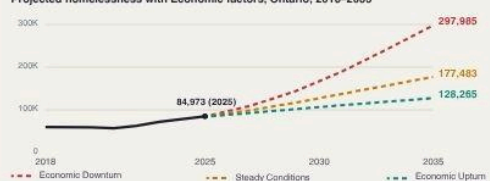
Carried by municipalities, those who pay property taxes have increased by 90% since 2018.

65.2%

Of 2024 spending went to emergency shelters; prevention received just 4.9%

5 WITHOUT ACTION, THIS COULD MORE THAN TRIPLE BY 2035

Projected homelessness with Economic factors, Ontario, 2018–2035



294,266+

In a pessimistic perspective, these individuals could be without stable housing by 2035 provided there is an economic downturn, a reality most would agree is unacceptable.

177,483

In regards to an economy with steady conditions homelessness is still projected to more than double, and still grows to 128,265 under an uplift. There needs to be intervention now rather than later.

6 ACTING COSTS LESS THAN DRIFTING — AND PAYS BACK

\$2.80 BACK FOR EVERY \$1 INVESTED

A capital program of ~\$36 billion towards new existing homes and build new ones is estimated to return roughly \$102 billion in total value over 25 years, by reducing long-run demand on health and justice systems and generating net fiscal savings.

Government Resource Summary & Fiscal Modeling (AMO, 2026)

\$11B / 10yr

This type of funding ends chronic homelessness: 75,650 new housing & support spaces available so they don't need to return through the system.

\$2B now

There is currently 5,700 housing spaces; 8,400 people out of encampments.

Sources: AMO/OMSSA/NOSDA — Municipalities Under Pressure: The Human & Financial Cost of Ontario's Homelessness Crisis (Jan 2025); Municipalities Under Pressure One Year Later (Jan 2026).

Figures are counts and expenditures reported by Ontario's 47 municipal service managers; projections are AMO scenario modelling. Chart lines between reported points are interpolated.

C4 Cross-Campus Capstone · Summer 2026 · Team C1 — Affordability.

10.2 - Awareness Campaign #1

Government of Ontario Homelessness Expenditure Report

Item	Cost
Emergency Shelter Beds_____	-\$\$\$\$\$\$
Healthcare & Paramedics_____	-\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$
Police Enforcement_____	-\$\$\$\$\$
Shelter Workers Salaries_____	-\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$
Lost Tax Revenue	-\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$
Solving The Problem_____	+\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$
	+\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$
	+\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$\$

**Do You Know Where Your
Taxes Are Really Going?**

The Cost of Doing Nothing



10.3 - Awareness Campaign #2



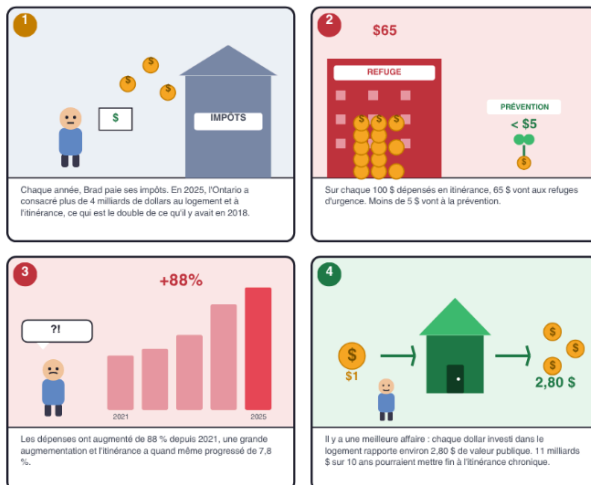
In 2025, 65,000 people experienced homelessness on a single night across 75 Canadian communities.

Scan here to learn more
Source: Everyone Counts 2025,
 Government of Canada.

10.4 - Awareness Campaign #3

LE DOLLAR DE BRAD. The Cost of Doing Nothing

VOICI BRAD.



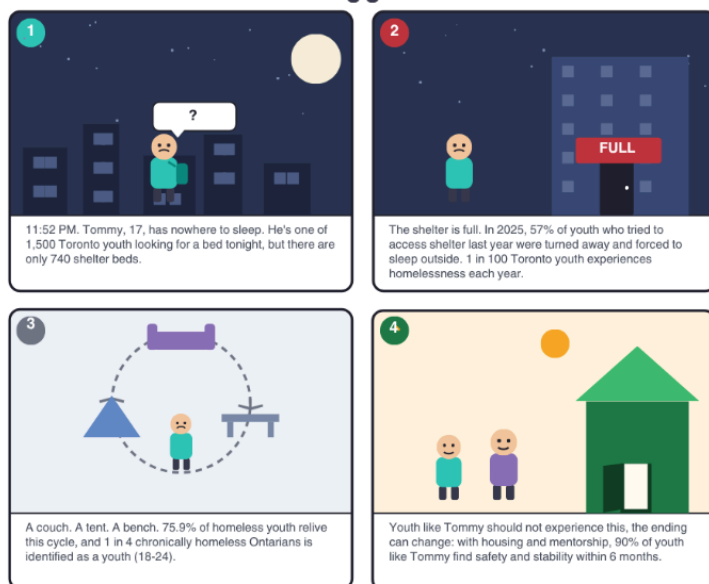
Brad ne paie pas pour mettre fin à l'itinérance ; il paie pour l'entretenir. Ça peut changer.

AMO/OMSSANOSDA — Municipalités sous pression (2025) - Municipalités sous pression, un an plus tard (2026)
Capstone Inter-campus C4 - GNO3100/5100 - Équipe C1 — Affordabilité

10.5 - Awareness Campaign #4

MEET TOMMY. The Cost of Doing Nothing

He's 17. Toronto has no bed for him tonight.



Tommy is one of 84,973 Ontarians who experienced homelessness in 2025. It doesn't have to be this way.

Covenant House Toronto (2025) - Youth Without Shelter (2026) - 2024 Street Needs Assessment - Oasis Youth Care (2026) - AMO (2026)
C4 Cross-Campus Capstone - GNO3100/5100 - Team C1 — Affordability

10.6 - Awareness Campaign #5



10.7 - Awareness Campaign #6



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